‘This story is going to really create a splash,’ was my gut reaction. Not all my senior editors were as convinced. ‘This is a BJP-driven operation, surely we need to do some verification before we can go on air with it.’ The more considered view that I eventually fell in line with was that the tapes on their own did not make a journalistically sound investigative report and the ‘evidence’ in them needed more examination. Remember, contrary to popular belief, we did not have Amar Singh or any Congress leader offering money on tape, either by way of audio or video.

Given the sensitive, even dramatic nature of the story, we decided to consult our lawyers. I also spoke to former solicitor general Harish Salve who advised restraint. ‘The tapes will not stand legal scrutiny without due diligence and could be seen as unlawful entrapment,’ was his expert opinion. After a long debate during our editorial meeting, we decided to hold off airing of the footage till we had done further investigation.

By now, it was 4 p.m. The BJP leaders who had organized the sting were getting increasingly impatient—they wanted us to telecast the tapes immediately while the vote was on. We said that a genuine, credible investigation meant there would have to be a process of cross-checking the information, especially as there were middlemen with questionable reputations involved. ‘Give us a few days, we will put it all together,’ I assured my BJP interlocutors.

The lawyer in Jaitley seemed to understand our predicament but not the others. The BJP was determined to block the nuclear deal vote. So, around 5 p.m. that evening, barely a few hours after we had caught the initial money exchange on camera, the BJP MPs went ahead to Parliament, displaying the bundle of notes in the Lok Sabha. By that one act, the BJP left us with no choice but to abort the investigation. Key players like Sanjeev Saxena just disappeared when we tried to track them down. I went to Parliament and met the Lok Sabha Speaker Somnath Chatterjee, and gave him a copy of the sting tapes. ‘You have done the right thing. It is now for the Delhi police to investigate further,’ he told me.

Three weeks later, we testified before a parliamentary committee on the cash-for-votes sting and placed all the tapes before them. Importantly, the